The Museum of Broken Relationships

By Andrea Gibson

Museum of Broken Relationships

(Pg 10-15) In Croatia, in 2006, Olinka and Drazen broke up.
Having no idea what to do with the relics
from the four years of their love, they created
the Museum of Broken Relationships.

For years now they've been collecting items
from the broken-hearted all over the world.

INTRODUCTION

In 2006, Olinka Vistica & Drazen Grubisic created a communal space, a kind of refuge for – and cathartic celebration of – the everyday objects that had outlasted love. These items, along with the anonymous, intimate stories each piece represented, quickly captured hearts and imaginations across the globe. As word spread, the tiny museum became a worldwide sensation.

Today, you are invited to explore our ultimate need for love and connection despite the difficulties that go with it.

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Each day, treasures arrive at the museum's door:
a small bottle of a lover's tears.

The last checkbook with both partners' names.
A shiny watch with the pin pulled out
the second he said ***I love you*** for the first time.
In the Museum of Broken Relationships

there is a toaster. Beside it, a note:
When I moved across the country
I took the toaster. That will show you.
How are you going to toast anything now?

In another display there is a cell phone.
Written beside it, the words: ***He gave me***
his own cell phone so I couldn't
call him anymore.

There is a letter ***T*** from a keyboard
from a couple whose online passion died
after their first real-life encounter.
The keyboard taken apart in a commitment

to never again trust a computer key
to open one's heart. In the Museum
of Broken Relationships, you can find a letter
from a thirteen-year-old boy to his first love in Sarajevo
written before leaving to escape the war.

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You can find an air sickness bag
from a couple whose relationship did not survive
the turbulence of long distance.

You can find an ax used to chop the furniture
of a partner who had an affair, giving new
traumatic meaning to the phrase
splitting up.

There is a jar of Love Incense
with a note that says, ***It simply***
doesn't work.

And in the Museum of Broken
Relationships in Croatia, there are three
juggling balls sewn by hand,

by my hands, from material
cut from my socks, you say,
though I am certain

it was my underwear.
Either way, the juggling balls
were made from what I wore

underneath what everyone could see
and sewn with precision
the way my grandma taught me

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before dying of a broken heart
and leaving me a collection of thimbles
so I could be someone

strong enough to keep things
from falling apart.
The first time I saw you

I fell apart.
I had no idea who you were.
You walked into a studio I was in

and walked out.
Minutes later I was a puddle
in the parking lot,

my friend's hand on my back
asking what was wrong.
I couldn't explain it.

It was 2003.
I had no woo-woo **in** me
back then. I didn't believe

in reincarnation.
I just knew I'd loved you once
and would again. Months later,

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still not knowing who you were,
I saw you on TV reporting the invasion
of Iraq, then the occupation of Palestine,

a blood fire in the sky above you
and you not flinching,
or I thought you weren't flinching

until we started sharing a bed
and I could see the war
behind your eyelids,

how you tore the covers
off every morning like a kid
unwrapping a gift.

Like the dawn of a simple day
was everything you'd ever
put on your Christmas list.

I'd still be sleeping when you'd leave
for circus practice. Circus practice,
where you'd walk the tightrope, twirl

on trapeze bars, then come home
and pull me into the front yard to teach me
how to toss juggling balls

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into a still-blushing sky.
When I think about why we broke up,
why you flew all the way to Croatia

to let go of the juggling balls I made you,
I know it's because I was a terrible juggler.
I couldn't figure out how to hold something

and set it free at the same time.
So I dropped the ball. Convinced myself
I was up in the air about you

when really I was up in the air about me.
It's what we do turn our bodies into museums
of what was broken. Blame

the checkbook, the affair, the bottled up
tears. Blame the toast going stale
the day after the wedding.

We rip the letter off the keyboard
instead of ***control, command, escape, delete.***
Say it was the turbulence

of long distance instead of the baggage
unclaimed. But at the carousel of clarity
(otherwise known as fifteen years of therapy).

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I see I wasn't running from the war
back then. I was running from the peace.
The love I did not believe I was worth.

And because that lie held so much grief,
I don't know that I ever got over you
as much as I got under

the engine of myself
to fix the machine of ***my*** love,
which now runs okay

but still runs way too much,
if you know what I mean,
and I know you know what I mean,

because this was not the first lifetime
we said goodbye
without wanting to say goodbye,
was it?

Spelling Bee Without Stinger

(Pg 45) ***I love myself***
is often spelled
g-o-o-d-b-y-e

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See This Through

(Pg 104-105) My therapist has a theory about love.
She says often we are believing a lie when we believe time is what helps us see each other more clearly. Says to consider the opposite might be true. Consider the beginning might actually be when our hearts have perfect vision.

What if what you saw ***then*** was the truth?
Your holiest self seeing someone else's holiest self?
What if what came after was the lie?
What if the disco ball never stopped sparkling, something just closed your eyes?
Your past, maybe?
The terror you carry inside?
The not enough or too much that raised you to do everything you could to ensure you'd be hurt more than you'd be loved.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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